

deceptive delivery breaking away from right-handers – was a variation he first encountered in Chennai's tennis-ball cricket circuit.

Ashwin not only adopted the carrom ball but perfected it in Test cricket. Of the 682 carrom-ball deliveries bowled in Tests since his debut, Ashwin alone accounted for 578. He also took 34 of the 39 dismissals credited to the carrom ball in this period.

Primarily reserved for right-handers, Ashwin delivered 337 of his carrom balls to them, claiming 24 wickets.

The Rival

Throughout their careers, Ashwin and Australian off-spinner Nathan Lyon were frequently compared, their performances scrutinised in parallel. While Lyon overtook Ashwin's Test wicket tally with a match-winning performance in the Boxing Day Test, the statistics reveal that Ashwin outshone his counterpart in nearly every head-to-head comparison. Ashwin even outperformed Lyon in Australia, despite often playing second fiddle to Ravindra Jadeja in away Tests.

Supporting Cast

During his retirement announcement press conference, Ashwin made it a point to acknowledge the contributions of his teammates, particularly his fielders, to his impressive Test wicket haul.

"I would like to thank Rohit [Sharma], Virat [Kohli], Ajinkya [Rahane], and [Cheteshwar] Pujara, who have taken those splendid catches around the bat to give me the number of wickets I've managed over the years," Ashwin remarked in Brisbane. Rahane was his most frequent collaborator, taking 34 catches off Ashwin's bowling, often while stationed at first slip. Kohli's impact extended beyond his 29 catches, as his fielding in the midwicket region helped build pressure during Ashwin's spells.

Among wicketkeepers, Wriddhiman Saha played a crucial role, contributing to 21 dismissals – 18 catches and three stumpings – off Ashwin's bowling.



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